Omar M. Dianalan

Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan (April 14, 1931 – 1990) was a Filipino lawyer, traditional sultan, and public servant from Marawi City, Lanao del Sur.

He served as Chief of Police of Marawi City, City Mayor of Dansalan (later Marawi City) for nearly two decades, Assemblyman in the Regular Batasang Pambansa under the Kilusang Bagong Lipunan (KBL) banner, and Representative for the First District of Lanao del Sur in the 8th Philippine Congress.

He is best remembered for leading the effort to officially designate Marawi as the "Islamic City of Marawi" in 1980, and for his steadfast advocacy on behalf of Bangsamoro communities during some of the most turbulent decades in the history of Muslim Mindanao.

Sultan Omar Dianalan Boulevard in Marawi City bears his name to this day.

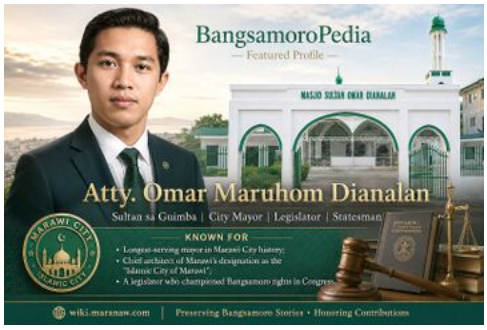
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EARLY LIFE AND ROYAL HERITAGE

Omar Maruhom Dianalan was born on April 14, 1931, in what was then the broader Lanao area of central Mindanao, the territory that would later be formally constituted as Marawi City.

Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan



Born

April 14, 1931

Marawi City (then Dansalan), Lanao del Sur, Philippines

Died

1990

Nationality

Filipino

Ethnicity

Maranao (Mëranaw)

Religion

Islam

Traditional Title

Sultan, Royal House of Guimba-Marawi

Education

Bachelor of Laws (LLB)

Philippine Bar Examination passer

Occupation

Lawyer, Politician, Sultan, Police Officer

Political Affiliation

Kilusang Bagong Lipunan (KBL; 1984–1986)

Positions Held

His middle name, "Maruhom," was not just a personal name: it pointed directly to a lineage of respected noble leaders who had long shaped the political and social landscape of the Maranao world.

Dianalan belonged to the Royal House of Guimba-Marawi, one of the traditional ruling structures within the sovereign confederation of Lanao sultanates.

The Lanao sultanates are among the oldest continuously functioning Islamic political institutions in the Philippines, and membership in a royal house carried real, practical weight in Maranao society, not just ceremonial prestige.

Over the course of his life, he earned the title of Sultan, a distinction that carried with it both the weight of hereditary authority and the expectations of a community that still looked to its traditional leaders for moral and political guidance.

He came from two prominent clans: the Maruhom clan and the Dianalan clan.

This dual heritage situated him at the intersection of multiple respected lineages in the Mëranaw (Maranao) community, a Muslim ethno-linguistic group centered around the shores of Lake Lanao in central Mindanao, and one of the major Bangsamoro peoples of the Philippines.

His upbringing, steeped in Islamic values, Maranao adat (customary law), and the obligations of noble birth, shaped how he would later approach public service: always with an eye toward community, always anchored in the traditions that gave his people their identity.

EDUCATION AND LAW

Dianalan pursued formal legal education and earned a Bachelor of Laws degree, later passing the Philippine Bar Examination to become a licensed attorney.

His professional title, "Atty.," was not merely decorative in his context.

In a country where the legal and political system had been constructed largely around a Christian-majority, Manila-centric framework, being a credentialed lawyer gave a Maranao leader from Lanao del Sur something invaluable: the tools to operate within that system on its own terms.

His legal training made him effective in halls of power where grassroots community connections alone were not always enough to get things done.

- Chief of Police, Marawi City
- City Mayor of Dansalan / Marawi City (c. 1968–1984)
- Assemblyman, Regular Batasang Pambansa (1984–1986)
- Representative, 1st District of Lanao del Sur, 8th Congress (1987–1992)
- Member, Board of Regents, Mindanao State University

Spouse

Daughter of late Lanao Governor Datu Hadji Alawi Mandangan Dimakuta

Children

Bae Omera Dimakuta Dianalan Lucman (among others)

Clan Affiliation

Maruhom clan; Dianalan clan

Notability

Maranao Sultan, Lawyer, and Statesman from Lanao del Sur; one of the longest-serving mayors in Marawi City history; chief architect of Marawi's designation as the "Islamic City of Marawi"; national legislator who championed Bangsamoro rights in Congress

Known For

- Signing City Council Resolution No. 19-A (April 15, 1980), officially declaring Marawi the "Islamic City of Marawi"
- Nearly two decades of mayoral service (c. 1968–1984)
- Sponsoring House Bill No. 20077 for the Bubong District Hospital
- Advocacy for Bangsamoro rights in the national legislature
- Namesake of Sultan Omar Dianalan Boulevard, Marawi City

It was precisely this combination of traditional authority and modern professional credentials that made him such a distinctive figure in Mindanao's political history.

PUBLIC SERVICE: POLICE, CITY HALL, AND BEYOND

Chief of Police

Dianalan began his public career in law enforcement, serving as Chief of Police of Marawi City.

In a city where tribal dynamics, clan relations, and community tensions were a daily reality for local governance, the police chief's role was never simply about crime: it involved navigating complex social situations, mediating disputes, and maintaining a working peace in an environment shaped by rido (clan conflict) and strong communal loyalties.

City Mayor of Dansalan / Marawi City

From roughly 1968 to 1984, Dianalan served as City Mayor of Dansalan, which was later officially renamed Marawi City.

That tenure of close to two decades made him one of the longest-serving elected mayors in the city's recorded history.

His years in city hall coincided with a deeply turbulent period in Mindanao: the declaration of Martial Law in 1972, the armed conflict between the Moro National Liberation Front (MNLF) and the Philippine government, and the broader struggle over Bangsamoro self-determination that would define Muslim Mindanao for generations.

Through all of that, Dianalan focused on what he could directly influence: infrastructure development, improving the city's revenue base, encouraging investment, and maintaining enough stability to allow ordinary life to continue.

The work was incremental, unglamorous, and necessary.

The Islamic City Declaration

The high point of his mayoral tenure, and arguably the achievement most associated with his name, came on April 15, 1980.

On that date, Dianalan signed City Council Resolution No. 19-A, which formally declared Marawi the "Islamic City of Marawi."

The move was both culturally resonant and strategically calculated.

With roughly 92 percent of the population identifying as Muslim, Marawi already was, in every practical sense, an Islamic city.

The official declaration formalized what the community already knew about itself, and it carried concrete strategic value: it positioned Marawi to attract development assistance and investment from Muslim-majority countries and organizations in the Middle East.

It also sent a clear signal to Manila and to the broader Philippine public that Marawi's identity was not something to be diluted or sidelined in the name of national uniformity.

The designation made Marawi the country's only predominantly Muslim chartered city, a distinction it holds to this day.

NATIONAL LEGISLATURE

Batasang Pambansa (1984–1986)

Dianalan moved to the national stage in 1984, winning election as an Assemblyman in the Regular Batasang Pambansa under the Kilusang Bagong Lipunan (KBL) banner, the ruling political party of the Marcos administration.

His tenure in the Batasan covered the final years of Marcos rule, a period of intense political pressure that culminated in the People Power Revolution of February 1986 and the restoration of democratic governance.

8th Philippine Congress (1987–1992)

After the restoration of the bicameral Congress under the 1987 Constitution, Dianalan won election as Representative for the First District of Lanao del Sur in the 8th Philippine Congress, serving from 1987 to 1992.

His time in Congress was marked by consistent advocacy for his constituents and for the broader Bangsamoro community.

Contemporaries described him as a fierce defender of Moro rights in the House, working to address historical injustices and the structural marginalization that Muslim Mindanao had faced for decades.

Among his concrete legislative contributions was the sponsorship of House Bill No. 20077, which sought to establish the Bubong District Hospital, a measure aimed at expanding access to healthcare in Lanao del Sur.

He also helped create the legislative framework for a Drug Addiction Rehabilitation Center in Barangay Amai-Pakpak, Marawi City.

BOARD OF REGENTS, MINDANAO STATE UNIVERSITY

Beyond his roles in local and national government, Dianalan served on the Board of Regents of Mindanao State University (MSU), the flagship state university of Muslim Mindanao and one of the most important educational institutions in the Bangsamoro region.

His presence on the Board of Regents reflected both his community stature and his genuine interest in education as a vehicle for Bangsamoro advancement.

FAMILY

Dianalan married into another prominent Lanao family: his wife was the daughter of the late Lanao Governor Datu Hadji Alawi Mandangan Dimakuta.

Their union linked two powerful political and traditional families, reinforcing the networks of clan and governance that shaped political life in the Lanao region.

Among their children was Bae Omera Dimakuta Dianalan Lucman, who went on to build a distinguished public career of her own, serving as Administrator of the Cooperative Development Authority, Vice Governor of Lanao del Sur, and Secretary of the Office on Muslim Affairs.

LEGACY

Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan died in 1990.

Those who knew him remembered a man who kept his door open to anyone who came with a need, regardless of faith or background.

In a political environment where personal enrichment was common, he stood apart: contemporaries noted that he died without having accumulated great personal wealth, a quiet testament to the kind of public servant he had chosen to be.

His integrity stayed intact through nearly three decades of public life, across the most difficult political terrain his region had ever faced.

The city he served has not forgotten him.

Sultan Omar Dianalan Boulevard, the major commercial and arterial corridor of Marawi City, carries his name today, a fitting monument for a man who spent his career building things that lasted.

His story is, in many ways, the story of Maranao leadership itself: how a person could hold two worlds at once, the ancient obligations of a sultan and the modern responsibilities of an elected official, and serve both without betraying either.

SEE ALSO

- Marawi City
- Lanao del Sur
- Bangsamoro Autonomous Region in Muslim Mindanao (BARMM)
- Mindanao State University
- Maranao people
- Batasang Pambansa
- 8th Congress of the Philippines
- Islamic City of Marawi

REFERENCES

This source **article** (https://grok.com/c/16df72e1-532a-45cd-bc82-dc557274102f?rid=01443388-b903-403f-a273-ef14f3ec2e41) offers only a glimpse into the life of Sultan Atty. Omar Maruhom Dianalan.

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